

Slave ownership

The South by this time was a socially and economically diverse region. In the mountainous areas of northern Alabama, eastern Kentucky, Tennessee, and western Virginia, there were few plantations. Most whites farmed to support their families and traded locally. The majority of these yeomen farmers owned no slaves, although they still supported the institution.

It was on the cotton and tobacco plantations where most slaves toiled. Other slaves were house servants, and a growing number worked as skilled artisans or were hired out in urban areas. The price of an enslaved person quadrupled between 1800 and 1860, indicating a growing demand for Black labor even as the number of slaves increased. During this same period, more than 800,000 slaves from the Eastern states were sold or moved to work on the new cotton lands of the Southwest, breaking the ties of enslaved families in the process.

Southerners started to see their society as distinctive and threatened. Politicians and intellectuals began to defend slavery as a “positive good.” Paternalism on the plantation was compared with the situation of Northern workers desperately seeking employment, which created class tension.

350,000 The number of Southerners who had slaves in 1850—less than 25 percent of the white population. Half of enslavers had five slaves or fewer; only one percent had a hundred or more.

Splits emerge

Church ministers and congregations were divided. Well before the rise of sectional political parties, the three largest Protestant groups—Baptists, Presbyterians, and Methodists—formally split their national denominations into sectional factions. The Presbyterians were first to split in 1837, followed by the Baptists in 1844. In the Methodist Church, the largest denomination, a lengthy debate over the right of an enslaver to serve as a presiding bishop triggered the formation of the breakaway Methodist Episcopal Church South in 1846. For the vast majority of Southerners, slavery was not a sin—